

implies is the fact that the traditional model where production was centralised and the goods were distributed to location where they are needed might become redundant. With advancements in technology, the production centres could be localised and production could even take place in people's homes. You pay for the raw materials and the product's schematics and make it yourself. Even if the per unit cost of manufacturing is more when compared to traditional means, it would definitely be offset by the fact that the costs incurred due to middlemen, distribution, storage and warehousing, buffer stocks and inventory would all be eliminated. If the product's schematics are freely available on the web, the costs are reduced further.

The localised production could also result in the manufacturers producing products tailored to the preferences of a particular community. For example, an Alaskan production unit of an automobile company would be able to produce versions of the product that would do better in that particular market and not worry about the economies of scale for the same reasons mentioned above. With localised production units, the manufacturer would also find it feasible to produce faster iterations of a product and get the customer's feedback



What happens next?

Another implication is that while quality control ensured that all products produced are the same, 3D printing would lead to more personalised products reflecting the tastes of the individual thus promoting uniqueness.

While the first two implications would only result in manufacturers rethinking their strategies, the next implication might lead to a shift in power and 'global dominance'. Over the years, China has used its labour force to its advantage and has become the global leader in manufacturing. With 3D printing taking a hold, China may no longer be the first name a manufacturer looks up when they decide to start production.

Add to this the fact that the Chinese authorities have accommodated the producer's every need and have developed a highly specialised labour force, there just might be a situation where the tables could turn.